ALLY WEALTH • AUTHOR VISIBILITY CONSULTANT

Book Description Writing Guide

A practical method for writing clear, compelling and accurate book descriptions.

A practical workbook and reference guide

EDUCATIONAL RESOURCE • 2026 EDITION

How to use this guide

A book description is a sales and orientation tool. Its job is to help the right reader recognise the book and decide whether to explore it. It should not misrepresent the manuscript, over-explain the plot or rely on empty superlatives. This guide offers a repeatable drafting and editing process.

Work through the pages in order. Use the prompts to make decisions, record assumptions and identify actions. You can revisit a page when your book, audience or publishing plan changes.

Keep the work evidence-aware. Platform interfaces, policies and marketplace features change. Verify current official guidance before acting on platform-specific instructions. Treat examples as planning aids, not guarantees.

Make it your own. Not every tactic belongs in every campaign. Choose the actions that fit your book, resources, readers and values.

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01 / FIELD GUIDE

Know the description’s job

A description is not a synopsis, review or author biography. It presents the book’s promise, gives enough context to create interest and helps a reader judge fit.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **know the description’s job**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

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Working notes

02 / FIELD GUIDE

Start with the reader

Write down what the intended reader is looking for: a genre experience, a question answered, a problem explored or an emotional journey. Use this to decide which details deserve space.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **start with the reader**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

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Working notes

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Identify the central hook

Find the most distinctive premise, conflict, question or transformation. A strong hook is specific and understandable without requiring the reader to know the whole story.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **identify the central hook**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Choose the right structure

A fiction description may introduce a protagonist, disruption, stakes and dilemma. Nonfiction may introduce the reader's challenge, the book's approach and the practical or intellectual value.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **choose the right structure**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Write a one-sentence premise

Summarise the book in one sentence without trying to include every subplot or chapter. This sentence is a drafting tool, not necessarily the final opening.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **write a one-sentence premise**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Open with specificity

Avoid broad statements such as ‘a journey like no other’. Use a concrete situation, question or tension that belongs to this book.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **open with specificity**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Establish stakes

Explain what may be lost, gained, discovered or changed. Stakes can be emotional, practical, relational, intellectual or physical, depending on the book.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **establish stakes**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Create curiosity without confusion

Leave meaningful questions open, but give enough context for readers to understand the premise. Mystery is not the same as vagueness.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **create curiosity without confusion**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Use genre signals accurately

Readers use familiar genre language to decide what to read. Include relevant cues while avoiding promises—such as romance, humour or a guaranteed happy ending—that the book does not fulfil.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **use genre signals accurately**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Balance plot and atmosphere

Some books are best introduced through action; others through voice, setting or theme. Choose the balance that reflects the actual reading experience.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **balance plot and atmosphere**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Write nonfiction benefits carefully

State what the book covers and who may find it useful. Avoid guaranteed transformations, medical or financial promises, or claims beyond the author's evidence and qualifications.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **write nonfiction benefits carefully**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Avoid the chapter-by-chapter summary

A description should create a decision, not retell the entire book. Select the most persuasive elements and omit secondary details.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **avoid the chapter-by-chapter summary**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Use short, readable paragraphs

Break dense copy into scannable sections. Vary sentence length and remove repeated ideas. Check how the description appears on a phone.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **use short, readable paragraphs**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Choose keywords naturally

Use reader language where it fits. Do not stuff phrases or add unrelated terms. Search metadata is a separate task from writing persuasive copy.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **choose keywords naturally**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Make the voice consistent

The description should sound compatible with the book and author. A comic novel, a literary memoir and a technical guide require different registers.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **make the voice consistent**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Use proof points responsibly

If you include awards, credentials, endorsements or review excerpts, verify them and obtain permission where needed. Do not invent acclaim or imply an endorsement that does not exist.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **use proof points responsibly**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Decide whether to use a call to action

A simple invitation can work, but it should not distract from the reader promise. Avoid pressure or artificial urgency.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **decide whether to use a call to action**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Draft several openings

Write three different openings: premise-led, character- or reader-problem-led, and atmosphere- or question-led. Compare them against audience fit and clarity.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **draft several openings**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Edit for precision

Replace vague adjectives with concrete nouns and verbs. Remove claims that could apply to any book. Check names, facts, chronology and spelling.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **edit for precision**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Check spoiler boundaries

Ask what a new reader needs to know and what should remain a discovery. For a series, avoid revealing a previous book’s major twist in a later description.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **check spoiler boundaries**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Adapt for different channels

Retailer descriptions, website summaries, media pitches and social captions have different lengths and purposes. Adapt the core message rather than pasting one version everywhere.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **adapt for different channels**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Create a short description

Prepare a compact version for catalogues, retailer fields or promotional graphics. Keep the core premise and audience signal intact.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **create a short description**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Create a long description

Use additional space to explain themes, scope or structure when the context supports it. Do not add padding merely to reach a word count.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **create a long description**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Test with target readers

Ask a few suitable readers what they think the book is about, who it is for and what questions remain. Look for misunderstanding, not only praise.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **test with target readers**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Review cover and description together

Check whether the visual and written promises reinforce one another. A mismatch can attract readers who expected a different genre or experience.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **review cover and description together**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Evaluate conversion signals

Where data is available, compare visits and actions over a reasonable period. Remember that traffic source, price, reviews and seasonality also influence results.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **evaluate conversion signals**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

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Build a description brief

Record audience, positioning, genre cues, hook, stakes, proof points, spoiler boundaries and required versions. This helps collaborators work from the same facts.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **build a description brief**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Common description problems

Look for generic openings, excessive backstory, too many names, unexplained jargon, unsupported claims, inconsistent tense and unclear reader benefit.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **common description problems**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Final proofreading checklist

Read aloud, check names and facts, inspect mobile layout and compare every claim with the manuscript. Ask someone unfamiliar with the book to explain what they expect.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **final proofreading checklist**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

- Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?
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Working notes

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Your description drafting worksheet

Complete the premise, reader promise, hook, stakes, genre signals, proof points and short/long versions. Save the approved copy with a date and version number.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **your description drafting worksheet**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

- Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?
- What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?
- What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes